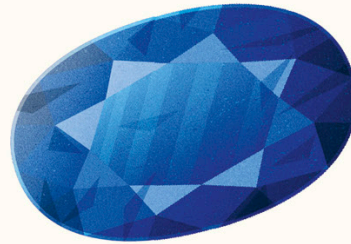


# Corundum



Ruby



Sapphire

What twinkles like a star but is hard as stone? A gem! Gems are pieces of precious rocks and minerals that have been cut to make them sparkle. Two of the most famous gems are rubies and sapphires. Both are made of the same mineral – corundum – but tiny amounts of other chemicals change their colour. Rubies are always red, and sapphires are usually blue, but they can also be other colours including yellow, green, and orange.

The biggest and brightest gems can be very valuable. The Sunrise Ruby weighs only 5 g (0.18 oz) but sold for over US\$30 million in 2015. The Stuart Sapphire is a jumbo jewel, almost 4 cm (1.5 in) long, found in a crown belonging to the British royal family.

*Corundum is extremely hard.  
Only one other mineral is  
harder – diamond.*

